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Expansion

Jazz was born. But the unique thing about it is not its existence —there have been plenty of specialized local musical idioms—but its extraordinary expansion, which has practically no cultural parallel for speed and scope except the early expansion of Mohammedanism. This is what we must therefore consider next. It falls, broadly, into phases: c. 1900–17 when jazz became the musical idiom of black popular music all over America while some of its gimmicks (e.g. syncopation and ragtime) became a permanent component of Tin Pan Alley; 1917–29 when ‘strict’ jazz expanded very little, but evolved quite rapidly, and when a highly diluted infusion of jazz became the dominant idiom of Western urban dance music and pop songs; 1929–41 when ‘strict’ jazz began its conquest of European minority audiences and *avant-garde* players, and a much less diluted form of jazz (‘swing’) permanently entered pop music. The real international triumph of jazz, the penetration of yet ‘purer’ jazz idioms into pop music—New Orleans jazz, *avant-garde* modern jazz, and the country and gospel blues—have come since 1941.

The traditional picture of the diffusion of jazz is as simple as it is mythical: it stayed in New Orleans until the American Navy closed down the red light quarter in 1917, after which the musicians, some already with experience on the river-boats, migrated up the Mississippi to Chicago, and thence all over America, notably to New York. This picture not only lacks much relation to the facts, but also makes it totally impossible to understand how jazz developed as it actually did. For it implies that other musicians learned their jazz relatively late, and that they learned it in terms of New Orleans music. But this is demonstrably not so. Though New Orleans musicians were highly appreciated and very influential, New Orleans jazz as a *style* had virtually no lineal descendants, except among a group of young white jazz fans from the

Middle West who anticipated later fashions among the jazz public. Plenty of jazz who played in black bands by the early 1920s, but it was not in New Orleans style jazz, except when played by groups actually hailing from that city. Plenty of black bands were started in that period, but they contained surprisingly few players from the Delta, or even the Mississippi river-line, and very few indeed from Chicago. In fact, jazz emerged after the First World War as a highly varied music, played by musicians all over the country, the New Orleans style being only one among many, though still the most fully formed. Purists may of course argue that what the rest played was 'not real jazz', but this type of argument need not detain us.

The truth is that New Orleans players began to tour the hinterland and the rest of the country almost immediately, even getting as far as Europe, though nobody took much notice of them there before 1919. It would be tedious to list such of their movements as have been traced. We need only recall that in 1907 Jelly-Roll Morton reports how he went to Chicago, then to Houston, Texas, then to California, then back to New Orleans via Texas and Oklahoma, getting a new girl in each place and winning a lot of money at pool. Touring was part of the economy of entertainers anyway, and New Orleans, a major reservoir of musicians even before the rise of jazz, must have been frequently tapped. W. C. Handy recalls how his road company (Mahara's Minstrels) took over two New Orleans clarinetists between 1900 and 1903, when black players took over that instrument, hitherto to preserve of whites: obviously bandmasters would think of New Orleans.¹ The Delta musicians themselves soon discovered the possibilities of engagements further afield.

No doubt they stimulated musicians wherever they went; nothing advances jazz more than a mixing of players. No doubt they influenced ambitious boys, who in turn taught others within the radius of their music. But, as we have seen, all black America was ready to burst out into one form or another of the jazz idiom anyway. Nor was the New Orleans influence the only one. The ragtime pianists, the blues singers in their tent shows, were already on the scene. In the East, for instance, a local piano style, based on ragtime and Appalachian gospel shouts, was almost contemporary with the New Orleans players. Walter Gould ('One

Leg Shadow') born in Philadelphia in 1875, piano player and obscure salesman of lottery tickets, or Eubie Blake (born 1883) claim to recall men who 'ragged' quadrilles and schottisches even before their birth: Old Man Sam Moore, 'No Legs' Casey, Bud Minor, 'Old Man Metronome' French.² New Orleans was no pioneer to these North-Easterners, who were in any case out of its normal line of influence. How little the simple 'New Orleans' myth reflects reality may be illustrated by the example of Paul Howard, born 1895 in Steubenville, Ohio, of free black ancestry, whose musical career started in church. Gospel music stood at one of his sides, military music at the other; he acquired a saxophone from an ex-soldier before 1910, becoming the first black saxophonist in Los Angeles, where he migrated in 1911. There, it is true, he discovered New Orleans jazz with Keppard's New Orleans orchestra which played a two-week vaudeville season in 1915, and had some difficulty as a trained 'reading' musician in adapting himself to collective improvisation. But how far from New Orleans jazz were contemporary local bands like the Black-and-Tan Band which he joined, a cake-walking, ragtime brass band, originally from Texas, which reshuffled itself into a 'jazz band' as soon as the word had a saleable value in 1918?³ At most New Orleans accelerated whatever tendencies towards jazz existed locally.

By 1920, therefore, jazz was already a national idiom with different dialects. That is why the subsequent movements of jazz musicians reflect not only the traditional touring routes of vaudeville artists and minstrel shows, but, with some precision, the routes of migration of ordinary blacks. For this mass migration, rather than the temporary purity drive in New Orleans, pushed even the New Orleans musicians northwards. (The best friends of the city will not claim that it has ever lacked a considerable and publicly tolerated night life for more than a few months on end.) From about 1916 the blacks who had hitherto been remarkably immobile flooded north in extraordinary numbers. The combined black population of New York, Chicago, Philadelphia, and Detroit almost doubled between 1910 and 1920, and more than doubled between 1920 and 1930. In absolute figures, it rose from 226,000 in 1910 to 902,000 in 1930. In 1910 there had been only three cities with black populations of 90,000 or more; in 1920 there were six, in 1930 eleven including three

with black populations of over 200,000. The black population of Chicago almost trebled, that of Harlem almost doubled between 1910 and 1920, and both more than doubled again in the next ten years. To take a single year, in 1922–3 nearly half a million blacks migrated from the Southern states.⁴

Evidently jazz spread with the migrants. Just as ordinary blacks from Florida, Alabama, Georgia, etc., were likely to move along Eastern routes towards Washington, Baltimore, Philadelphia, and New York, so did the musicians from these areas: Duke Ellington's orchestra (1926) contained no New Orleans man and only one player from St Louis, but it did contain men from Massachusetts, New York, New Jersey, Virginia, South Carolina, Washington D.C., and Indiana. This was natural, for it was a Washington-New York band.⁵ Just as migrants from the Delta were likely to move up-river, so did the New Orleans and Memphis musicians. The black quarters of St Louis were likely to attract migrants (and musicians) from the middle Mississippi valley, those of Kansas City from the Oklahoma-Texas hinterland. There is, in fact, no great mystery about the geographical diffusion of jazz musicians.

There is, however, a mystery about the notable musical centres which were established as the result of this mass migration. For some of the major black ghettos proved far more receptive to jazz than others, or rather, produced more musicians and independent musical activity than others. Obviously New York and Chicago led the field in the North, though Chicago, oddly enough, produced surprisingly few black orchestral jazz players of standing for a city so legendary for its jazz.* The much smaller border metropolis of Louisville, Kentucky, compares favourably with it.[†] Perhaps the youth of Chicago's black belt, or the competition of the famous out-of-town players who all passed through the city, accounts for this scarcity. Then there is the odd fact that the more industrial the city to which blacks migrated the less fertile apparently its jazz. Detroit, Cleveland, and for that matter Chicago itself, are instances. Few black ghettos grew more rapidly than Detroit, which had under 6,000 coloured inhabitants in 1910 and 120,000 in 1930. Few were more purely industrial. Yet thought the city contained a great deal of jazz, being the headquarters of both leading white and black bands

(McKinney's Cotton-Pickers and Jean Goldkette's Orchestra), it is extremely hard to think of a prominent jazz player of the premodern period who actually hails from there. In the modern period, however, Detroit became one of the most important breeding-grounds of young musicians. Perhaps the relatively well-paid industrial jobs took away boys who would otherwise have been driven into entertainment. On the other hand, there is Pittsburgh, a typically industrial city, which has been extraordinarily fertile in producing original jazz musicians.⁵ But then, Pittsburgh seems always to have been an exceptionally thriving centre of night-life and entertainment for the Pennsylvania industrial belt and—perhaps because of local segregation—of black consciousness.

It is perhaps less surprising that cities on the fringe of the South should have been good nurseries for jazz, though a little puzzling why some of the older centres of the Deep South—Atlanta, Charleston—have not been strikingly productive; or for that matter why, in the North, Philadelphia, which ran Harlem close in numbers until 1920, has made infinitely feebler contributions to jazz. But why is it that among the Southern border cities—Washington D.C. and Baltimore, St Louis and Louisville, Oklahoma City and Dallas—Kansas City, Mo., with barely more than 30,000 black inhabitants in 1920 and not yet 100,000 in 1940, should have become so abnormally important in the evolution of jazz? Because it was a great centre of communication? Perhaps. As Iain Lang has said, the list of Kansas City's railroads is more than a catalogue, it is almost an incantation:⁶

Chicago Great Western, Union Pacific, Missouri Pacific, Frisco System, Chicago Burlington and Quincy, Atchison Topeka and Santa Fe, Chicago Milwaukee and Saint Paul, Chicago and Alton, Wabash, Kansas City Southern, Chicago Rock Island and Pacific, Missouri Kansas and Texas, Leavenworth Kansas and Western, Kansas City Mexico and Orient, St Louis Kansas City and Colorado, Quincy Omaha and Kansas City, St Joseph and Grand Island.

Because it never suffered from the Depression, as some say? Perhaps. Certainly, being run by the most corrupt political machine in the U.S.A.,

it remained as wide open as the Kansas cattle towns in the great days of the West, and a much bigger employer of musicians than most cities. Actually, its jazz history goes back to the 1890s, when it was one of the pioneer centres of ragtime.

The truth is that, though we may guess at the answers to some of these questions, we do not know. A great deal more will have to be discovered about the sociology of black immigrant communities, a great deal more information will have to be collated about their entertainments, a good deal more careful biographical analysis of players and their careers will have to be done, before such fascinating historical puzzles can be solved. In the meantime we can note them only in passing.

This huge increase in the black public produced the phenomenon which has given us our basic documentation of jazz: the 'race record'.⁷ From 1920 on, gramophone companies found it worth while to issue records purely for the black market, and from 1923 several companies systematically built up such 'race-catalogues'. The most famous of them is that of the Okeh company (1923–35) which included, among much rare folk-material, most of Louis Armstrong's early small-group work.⁸ Thanks to the extraordinary growth of this market between 1923 and 1927 almost every artist who had ever been heard by anyone connected with show business had a chance of at least one or two recording sessions. Some of those recorded on race series—especially the most primitive singers and pianists—remain to this day little more than names, perpetuated on two or three historically invaluable discs: Bessie Tucker, Montana Taylor, 'Speckled Red', Romeo Nelson, Dobby Bragg, Henry Brown. Black orchestral jazz did not long remain confined to the 'race series', but such series have continued (re-baptized 'rhythm and blues' in deference to black susceptibilities) to this day. The recent rock-and-roll vogue rests almost entirely on the pillaging of such catalogues by Tin Pan Alley.

Authentic undiluted jazz made no great impact on the general white public, though the northern tour and the records of the (white) Original Dixieland Jass Band in 1917 caused a temporary sensation, and conveniently serve to mark the beginning of the 'jazz age'. Both the date and the label are misleading, for the 'jazz age' had begun—though not

under that precise trade-mark—some years earlier and it was not so much an age of jazz as of the mass conversion of ordinary pop and dance music to some idea vaguely involving syncopation, rhythm, instrumental novelty effects such as barnyard imitations, and the like. This new idiom was undoubtedly influenced by jazz, but it is safe to say that ninety-seven per cent of what the average white North American and European heard under that label between 1917 and 1935 had as little to do with jazz as the costume of drum-majorettes has with battledress.

The triumph of this hybrid jazz is so important a phenomenon that we must look at it more closely. In the first instance it was almost certainly due to the triumph of ballroom dancing and especially—among the younger twentieth-century generation—of a fairly fast type of dance. The typical nineteenth-century pop music number, on which the fortunes of Tin Pan Alley then rested, was designed for singing solo or in chorus, and indeed was rather hard to dance to, as may be tested by trying to do so to Stephen Foster or the classical pub and barber-shop repertoire, say *Nellie Dean*. But from about 1910 on, publishers seem to have observed that no song was likely to become a smash-hit unless it was also danceable. Within a decade practically all songs would automatically be supplied with a dance orchestration in strict time, however little suited to them. (The pop term ‘ballad’ for any song which cannot be otherwise classified echoes the sound of these Victorian warblings.)⁸ Ragtime and jazz rhythms, which can be used to adapt practically any tune for dancing, were naturally invaluable. The history of ordinary popular dancing is, as usual, rather obscure and we do not know exactly how and why the vogue for ballroom dancing grew, though we can trace it in its more commercial and publicized aspects: the first ‘dance marathon’ put on by Sid Graumann (of Graumann’s Chinese Theatre in Hollywood) in 1910, the vogue for ‘*thé dansants*’ on the eve of the First World War, which made the fortunes of the famous dancing team of Irene and Vernon Castle, the small American neighbourhood dance halls grossing 2,500 dollars a week on a dime admission, the penny dances in parks organized by the Cincinnati city fathers in 1914, and the rest.⁹ (British dance halls came later: the Hammersmith Palais in 1919, characteristically with the Original Dixieland Band as resident orchestra.) Fortunately it is the fact

of the dancing vogue rather than its explanation which concerns us here. I daresay it was closely connected with the loosening of Victorian conventions of social behaviour, and especially with the emancipation of women.

At all events, the dancing fashion was also a search for newer, faster, and less conventional dance rhythms and dance sounds which edged aside even the very resistant dances of the late nineteenth century—above all the waltz—with more exciting rhythmical Africanisms, North or South American.

From 1900 the invention of new rhythmic dances became a minor industry. The crop of 1910–15, Turkey Trot, Bunny Hug, etc., produced the most lasting formula, the Foxtrot. It is safe to say that without the foxtrot and its cousins (the Shimmy, originally a Barbary Coast indecency, was particularly popular in Europe in the 1920s) the triumph of hybrid jazz in pop music would have been unthinkable, just as the advance of Latin-American rhythms rested firmly on the adoption of the tango, also on the eve of the First World War. Subsequent innovations—the Black Bottom, Charleston, Lindy Hop, Big Apple, Truckin’ and the rest—mostly borrowed from those abundant sources of new dances the Western and Mid-Western cabarets, and later the big Harlem dance halls—have been mainly temporary crazes.

The dancing vogue automatically brought an infiltration of Afro-American idioms into pop music: even the Castles had a black band, and a craze for drumming and drum solos, such as has periodically seized the more moronic part of the public, was already running its course in 1914–16. From 1912 or so the blues entered popular music. W. C. Handy published some of his finest pieces between then and 1916 (*Memphis Blues*, *St Louis Blues*, *Yellow Dog Blues*, *Beale Street Blues*), and 1916 saw a battle between pop music publishers over the priority of their respective blues.⁹ From about the same time the term ‘jazz’ (or jass, jaz) came to be used as a generic label for the new dance music, since few knew that it had hitherto been an African slang word for sexual intercourse.¹⁰ It was adopted rapidly and almost universally, no doubt because by 1916–17 the need for such a label was obvious. There was not only the Original Dixieland Jass Band, which was a jazz band, but a host

of competing ‘inventors of the jazz dance’, and of Tin Pan Alley numbers of the genus ‘everybody’s doing the X now’: *Cleopatra Had a Jazz Band*, *Everybody’s Crazy ’bout That Doggone Blues*, *Mr Jazz Himself*, by Irving Berlin, who was quicker off the mark with jazz than with ragtime; all from 1917. Former minstrel and quasi-military bands like Wilbur Sweatman’s, Isham Jones’s, and Paul Whiteman’s drove their bandwagons in the new style, and those who could not, added a saxophone to their string trios and called themselves jazz bands anyway. Towards the end of 1917 ‘jazz bands’ were already being formed in Britain.¹¹

This mixture was not without its repercussions on authentic jazz. It was from the pop bands that the saxophone came. New Orleans players hardly knew or used it. ‘Straight’ minstrel bands had borrowed it from the military long since, as when Mahara’s Minstrels ‘picked up a quartet of saxophones in Chicago’ who ‘contributed wonderfully to the religioso’ when W. C. Handy played *The Holy City* as a cornet solo.¹² This mawkishness, which became the trade-mark of ‘sweet’ pop music in the 1920s, was about their limit then. Saxes entered jazz because they were popular with the audiences: King Oliver was prevailed upon to try a couple in the early 1920s because another band was attracting the customers with these instruments.¹³ Again, the pop song of the immediate post-war period provided a high proportion of the standards for the jazz repertoire of the twenties, especially among white bands, and stimulated the publication of a good many straight jazz and blues numbers. The characteristic repertoire of ‘Dixieland’ jazz was to consist largely of such numbers: *Indiana* (1917), *After You’ve Gone*, *Ja-da* (1918), *Someday Sweetheart*, *The World Is Waiting for the Sunrise*, *I’ve Found a New Baby*, *I Wish I Could Shimmy Like My Sister Kate*, *Royal Garden Blues*, *Ain’t Gonna Give Nobody None of My Jelly Roll* (1919), *Margie*, *Avalon*, *Japanese Sandman*, *Ida* (1920).¹⁴

The interesting thing about this vogue is that from the beginning it was seen not simply as just another, and perhaps abnormally deplorable, fashion in pop music, but as a symbol, a movement—at any rate something important. Moralists, of course, declared war on it immediately, as usual with a splendid inability to make up their minds

whether they objected to it because of its association with low life or the lower classes. The New Orleans *Times-Picayune*'s outburst is well known (20 June 1918):

Why is the jass music and, therefore, the jass band? As well ask why is the dime novel or the grease-dripping doughnut. All are manifestations of a low streak in man's tastes that has not yet come out in civilization's wash. Indeed, one might go further and say that jass music is the indecent story syncopated and counterpointed. Like the improper anecdote, also, in its youth, it was listened to blushing behind closed doors and drawn curtains, but, like all vice, it grew bolder until it dared decent surroundings and there was tolerated because of its oddity ... It gives a sensual delight more intense than the Viennese waltz or the refined sentiment and respectful emotion of an eighteenth-century minuet. In the matter of jass, New Orleans is particularly interested, since it has been widely suggested that this particular form of musical vice had its birth in this city.... We do not recognize the honour of parenthood, but with such a story in circulation, it behoves us to be the last to accept the atrocity in polite society?

'Unspeakable jazz must go!' cried the *Ladies' Home Journal* in 1921. Rabbi Stephen T. Wise, with the natural talent of clergymen for this type of statement, held that 'when America regains its soul, jazz will go—not before—that is to say it will be relegated to the dark and scarlet haunts whence it came and whither, unwept, it will return after America's soul is reborn'.¹⁵ The revulsion of conservative musical classicists was equally astonishing. Readers may find juicy examples in the files of the *Musical Times*.

On the other hand, the cultural *avant-garde* hailed it with equal enthusiasm and almost equal ignorance as the music of the machine age, the music of the future, the revitalizing force of the primitive jungle and so on, normally on the strength of hearing bands like Mr Jack Hylton's, which the author remembers as the accepted last word in jazz in Central European secondary schools, 1928–33. A characteristic, if late, example of this woolly rhapsodizing may be found in an article on 'The Heart of

Jazz', by a certain J.-H. Levesque (*Le Jazz Hot*, No. 23, 1938), which quotes Bergson, Stravinsky, Valéry, Minkowski, Blaise Cendrars, Rounnel, Thomas Aquinas, Apollinaire, and Lecomte de Nouy, and argues that jazz is the intensity of life as shown in other fields 'where life is manifested powerfully and freely'. Napoleon, Georges Carpentier, Theodore Roosevelt, Chaplin and cartoon films, Cochet the tennis player, Henry Ford, Rimbaud, Cendrars, Casanova, Picabia, Marcel Duchamp, Nuvolari and Malcolm Campbell the racing drivers are given as examples. There is, oddly, no reference to Cocteau, Picasso, or Freud. As a matter of fact, *avant-garde* musicians who actually heard some authentic jazz, such as Ernest Ansermet and Darius Milhaud, commented on it with considerable acumen and open-mindedness, though some of them were reluctant to tear themselves away from the beauties of 'this music which is as mechanized and as precise as a machine' (Darius Milhaud)¹⁶ to consider unmechanized jazz, and though their borrowings from it were superficial.

Within hybrid jazz itself there were also strivings and ambitions rarely found among the modest craftsmen of Tin Pan Alley. In a vague sense, not wholly determined by the advertising value of classiness, they felt it to be 'serious' in a way in which the idiom of, say, *Ireland Must Be Heaven, for My Mother Came from There*, or *There's a Broken Heart for Every Light on Broadway* was not. Paul Whiteman's famous Aeolian Hall concert of 1924, designed to establish the academic credentials of 'symphonic jazz', may deserve all the musical sneers of the really serious cats—but they rarely object to it because it tried to bring jazz to the concert platform. (Incidentally, Gershwin's *Rhapsody in Blue*, which had its first performance then, is a very reputable piece of jazz-influenced light music.) Jazz has had a hankering for recognition as something more than dance music ever since it emerged from the Deep South, and with reason.

Hybrid jazz spread with uncanny rapidity round the world, aided by the gramophone, the upper-class fashion for Anglo-Saxonisms and Americanisms (e.g. 'le five-o'clock', the tea-dance), and the prestige and horrible fascination of the U.S.A. in the heyday of Henry Ford, Wall Street, Lindbergh, and Prohibition. At the tailend of the twenties,

however, we observe the tiny beginnings of an expansion of the thoroughbred jazz among small obscure and untypical communities in Europe, and to a much lesser extent, in America.¹¹ The imported gramophone records of white New York musicians, and later of the great black players, were almost entirely responsible—in Europe at least—for the creation of these small groups of devotees.

It is fortunate that by the time the Depression swept across the U.S.A. a few hundreds—they could hardly yet be counted in thousands—of European jazz fans were ready. No doubt jazz historians have exaggerated the catastrophic effect of the slump on their music, though it is evident that bad times must decimate any industry which depends on the spending of spare money, except in so far as it relies on the rich who are never short of cash. Jazz did not die in America between 1929 and the start of the ‘swing’ craze in 1935. The new big black jazz bands, playing for dances, survived, though sometimes a little shakily. They were capable of competing with the cinema. Ellington, Lunceford, McKinney’s Cotton Pickers, Benny Moten, Earl Hines, Fletcher Henderson, Cab Calloway, Luis Russell, Andy Kirk, and others saw the Depression through, aided by the flourishing big clubs of gangster (and therefore ‘wide-open’) cities like Chicago and K.C., and by the major Harlem ballrooms. Indeed, for the big bands these were the formative years of their style. But innumerable marginal musicians and singers, men of traditional or inadaptably styles who had been carried by the modest prosperity of the black market, innumerable men who had preferred the casual high-stepping life of small combos in small clubs and gigs, found themselves on the streets.¹⁷ And for the record industry the slump was an unbelievable catastrophe: between 1927 and 1934 its sales dropped by 94 per cent.

The small European market could at least ensure that some records were made of certain kinds of jazz for which the American demand had virtually folded up. The most notable examples are those made by the great jazz Maecenas, John Hammond Jr, for the English Gramophone Company from 1933 on. Europe could also provide temporary jobs for American musicians, though political and union action cut down the scope for foreign touring in the 1930s.^{**}—Armstrong toured here—1932

and 1933–5, Fats Waller spent much of the thirties on this side of the Atlantic, Benny Carter was in Europe from 1935 to 1938, Coleman Hawkins from 1934 to 1939, Sidney Bechet toured frequently from 1928 to 1938, while several musicians expatriated themselves for long periods—the trumpeter Bill Coleman in Paris from 1933, the pianist Teddy Weatherford in China (joined in temporary exile by Buck Clayton 1934–6), the clarinetist Rudy Jackson in India and Ceylon. Their presence naturally helped to increase the number of European jazz-lovers.

European combinations trying to play ‘authentic’, or ‘hot’ jazz also began in the late 1920s. Fred Elizalde’s group in 1927 is the British pioneer. These were mostly small groups playing in odd nightclubs, or pick-up bands for recordings into which the already existing fifth column of jazz fans sometimes managed to talk the gramophone executives. Why, after all, should they not risk the £45 which covered all the salaries and expenses of Spike Hughes’ pioneer British for a session?¹⁸ From the early thirties on, the ‘hot’ public was large enough to found clubs and therefore modest audiences. The first Norwegian jazz club dates back to 1928, a now highly prosperous music publisher found it worthwhile to organize ‘hot record recitals’ in London in 1930, and by 1935 Denmark, which claimed to be ‘the world’s hottest country’, had jazz lectures in its schools and three jazz concerts a year organized by the leading serious newspaper.¹⁹ The most ambitious musical enterprise of these sects, and also the most original enterprise of European jazz up to the present, was the famous Quintet of the Hot Club of France (1934–9) whose star was the remarkable gypsy guitarist Django Reinhardt (1910–53). A number of mixed European-American recording sessions were also organized mainly in Holland and France, which became increasingly the European headquarters of jazz, thanks to the loudly and well-blown intellectual trumpets of its jazz writers and collectors.

If the Depression had almost exiled authentic jazz from America, that country was triumphantly reconquered in the middle 1930s. In 1935–40 pop music once again capitulated to jazz (now called ‘swing’), as it had done in 1914–20. Moreover, the jazz it capitulated to was a great deal more like the real thing than it had been in the days when anxious band leaders put some saxes behind their stands, some syncopation in their

arrangements, and played the *Blue Danube* as the *Blue Danube Blues*. In fact pop music adopted, almost *in toto*, the instrumental techniques and arrangements elaborated by the black players, and especially the black big bands, in the 1920s. This was all the easier, since these innovations in authentic jazz had themselves been the result of pop music influence, not to say the natural desire of black entertainers to jump on the white pop musicians' gravy train. At all events, the difference in *genre* between Benny Goodman's 'hot' band, which became the queen of the musical battlefield, and the ordinary 'sweet' band—itself infiltrated by hybrid jazz—was a great deal smaller in 1935 than such differences had been in 1917, when patrons at Reisenwebers in New York had actually to be instructed that the Original Dixieland Jass Band's sound was intended for dancing.

Why 'swing' conquered in the middle 1930s is therefore not quite so difficult a question as why jazz conquered pop music in 1914–20. It could in any case not have done so much earlier: the instrumental and orchestral innovations, and indeed the very rhythmical 'swing' from which the vogue took its name, were hardly elaborated before the second half of the twenties, and the Depression intervened after that. 'Swing' made its appeal by a combination of increasingly insistent rhythm and considerable noise. A series of brazen walls of sound advancing inexorably on the listener like Pacific breakers, a driving drum-pulse occasionally breaking out into volleys of virtuoso sharpshooting: such was its basic formula. Its appeal was almost exclusively to adolescents. The modern phase of pop music, in which the crucial section of the public stretches from the age of twenty-one backwards as far as pocket-money will allow, begins with the middle 1930s. At any rate youth—especially white college youth—made the fashion. Glen Gray Knoblaugh's Casa Loma Orchestra (anticipating the later Glenn Miller Band), which catered largely to college audiences in the early thirties, is said to have been the first white band with a deliberate jazz policy, and the pioneer of 'swing'. It was probably not quite the first. Benny Goodman's Band (formed in 1934), sold to business by an ex-college-boy executive, had little success until it hit the teenage and college public in California in the middle of 1935. The 'swing' public was a dancing public, but with a difference, for the athletic, acrobatic dances it evolved

(‘jiving’, ‘jitterbugging’) were simple releases of physical energy by rhythm rather than excuses for anticipating sexual caresses. It is extremely difficult to be very sexual when one is throwing one’s limbs about and whirling partners at arms’ length, especially in the aisles of concert halls and theatres. (This also anticipated later developments.) Indeed, ‘swing’ was no longer primarily a dancing music, but quite as much a music for ‘active listening’—tapping the feet, agitating the torso, but listening. The crowd of fans surrounding the bandstand, which have become characteristic of jazz occasions since, began in this period. This tendency to listen rather than to dance was not confined to ‘swing’: the leading ‘sweet’ band, Guy Lombardo’s Royal Canadians, claimed to owe its success largely to the discovery that its vast radio public rarely bothered to dance to it.²⁰ Perhaps the triumph of broadcasting accounts for this rediscovery of pop music as something which can be passively taken in. Consequently the characteristic product of the ‘swing era’ was the touring big band giving concert or variety performances as well as playing for dances: a formula which has lasted. However, since bands of this type and standard were virtually confined to the U.S.A., ‘swing’ made its foreign conquests—perhaps with the partial exception of Britain—mainly by means of the gramophone record. Its public abroad was therefore more restricted than that for the hybrid jazz of the 1920s and seems to have been largely a rather expanded version of the public for authentic jazz.

Meanwhile developments were taking place which were to make authentic jazz itself into an international mass movement, and eventually to commercialize it. These were the so-called ‘Revival’ movements, which produced their first important results in 1938–9 and their massive consequences, almost simultaneously in America and Europe, in the last years of the war and the first post-war years. They were quite unique phenomena, for they arose neither out of the internal logic of jazz development—i.e. the tendencies evolved by the players themselves—nor out of the logic of commercialism. They were almost wholly the products of intellectual doctrinaires who aimed, in the first place, at the rediscovery of the forgotten and ‘pure’ sources of jazz and the folk-music behind it. In America Roosevelt’s New Deal gave them a powerful

political impetus. An era which proudly claimed to go back to the grass-roots of American politics among the poor, the disinherited, the Radicals, revolutionaries, and Populists, found it only natural to go back also the grass-roots of American culture, and to rediscover the astonishing wealth of the American popular idiom. Nor was this mere archaeology. After all, organizers in Southern Illinois, Tennessee, and Alabama encouraged their militants with trade union blues, trade union hill-billy songs and trade union spirituals, for the simple reason that these were still a living, cultural language. Minstrel fiddlers and guitarists like the great Leadbelly (who was discovered and recorded for the Library of Congress at this period) made up union songs as naturally as gospel songs, and in the same manner:

*Have you belonged to dis union;
Do you belong to dis union;
We are union people.
Yes, lord, we went to dat office
And sho' have signed.
Got our name on de record
An we sho' done joined.*

The period from 1930 to 1941 therefore saw intellectuals 'going to the people', collecting, recording, and singing their music with passionate satisfaction. American folk-songs, old and new, became part of the atmosphere of the American left; no party in Greenwich Village or the Hollywood scriptwriters' belt became complete without someone who could sing *John Henry* to a guitar. Most of the material thus collected was 'pre-jazz'; but among the forgotten music thus resuscitated was early jazz also. The Lomaxes of the Library of Congress produced the most impressive single document of New Orleans jazz in 1938, when they opened their recording shops to a dapper elderly 'Creole Benvenuto Cellini' with gold rings and a diamond set in gold in his front incisor, who wished to defend his claim to be the only inventor of jazz: Ferdinand 'Jelly-Roll' Morton. In doing so they helped to create a classic.

A parallel movement was gaining force among the specialized jazz-lovers and collectors, whose ranks, of course, overlapped a good deal

with those of the musical or political New Dealers, friends of the Spanish Republic, Communists, and others, in Britain as in the U.S.A. Here it took the form chiefly of a protest against the increasingly ‘commercial’ tendencies of jazz in the swing era. Now that even good authentic jazz was in the headlines, the nostalgia for the old days, when only those in the know could find and appreciate it, became irresistible. From about 1938 collectors and critics began systematically to organize the recording of forgotten jazz and blues artists, but especially of attempts by the original players to recapture the quintessential jazz, which was that of New Orleans. Out of the many signposts in these years two deserve our special attention: the recording, by the French critic Hugues Panassié, of a splendid group of ‘New Orleans’ discs with Sidney Bechet, Tommy Ladnier, Mezz Mezzrow, and one or two others (1938), and the publication in 1939 of an erudite and nostalgic volume, *Jazzmen*, the first major fruit of years of devoted historical scholarship.²¹ In the international world of jazz-lovers every one of these records and publications, imported at first in single copies from America, created a sensation. In America itself the archaeologists went farther, and, by the middle of the war—1943 is the crucial year—had reached the point of actually restoring retired old New Orleans players to activity, buying them dentures and trumpets in the process, and launching them on a receptive public of young whites. California was the centre of this movement.

Even before the first grey-haired player tested his new denture on his new horn, young white players—for reasons to be discussed later the young black ones were quite immune to revivalism—had begun the painstaking reconstruction of the original New Orleans style. Lu Watters and the Yerba Buena Band, who opened around San Francisco at the tail-end of 1939, strongly supported by the Stanford and Berkeley students,²² were the pioneers of this movement, which is probably—and paradoxically—the most characteristically ‘white’ style in the history of jazz.^{††} The slowness with which records were issued in Europe (not to mention the impossibility of issuing American jazz in Nazi-occupied territories) postponed the emergence of the young revivalists outside America. However, by 1943 Australia had some (the Graeme Bell group),

by 1944 the star of New Orleans rose over the Red Barn pub in the unlikely Bethlehem of Bexley Heath, Kent (George Webb and his Dixielanders), while after liberation revival bands emerged, with fanatical purism in Paris (Claude Luter), with a little more freedom in Holland, where their foundations had been laid as far back as 1939 (Dutch Swing College), and elsewhere. The characteristic small cellar jazz band with its trumpeter trying to play like Louis Armstrong and its clarinet like Johnny Dodds, became part of the West and Central European scene.

For political or rather quasi-moral reasons it was kept out of Eastern Europe. Why the Soviet authorities took against jazz, about which they knew virtually nothing, is obscure. The prejudice against it long antedated the Cold War, though it was confined entirely to the Russians, western Communists and left-wingers being among the most enthusiastic champions of the music.²³ I dare say it was regarded as ‘decadent’ because it did not fit into the pattern of puritan social respectability which the Soviet authorities sought to inculcate. Nor did it. The most enthusiastic champions of jazz, and those most convinced of its moral harmlessness or positive value will not claim that it has a historical or natural affinity with puritanism. At all events the Russians kept it out, with the result that East Europeans had to get their jazz from the broadcasts of the AFN network and Radio Free Europe, or from western visitors to youth festivals. However, it is significant that when the restrictions of the later Stalin period were lifted in 1955–6 what emerged in Poland, East Germany, and Czechoslovakia was—the Dixieland revival.

Meanwhile jazz had made an even more important conquest: Africa itself. The astonishingly rapid urbanization of black Africa since 1940 produced the need for an urban popular music, which—for obvious reasons—the orthodox pop industry was slow to satisfy. In West Africa the music which thus emerged was chiefly based on local idioms, crossed with Caribbean influences, and a dash of New Orleans, but not very much. In South Africa, on the other hand, specially in Johannesburg, the urbanized black population took to American jazz, mainly derived, by the

sound of it, from the big bands of the swing era. Probably South Africa is today the most flourishing centre of creative jazz outside America.

By the middle 1950s, therefore, jazz had become a world idiom. It met with the greatest resistance in countries whose musical tradition was wholly non-European or non-African, e.g. in the Moslem world, and Asia (except for Japan, always open to Western influences), and in countries with particularly vigorous popular musical traditions, such as the Iberian and Iberian-American ones. Indeed, from these it actually encountered opposition. The Andalusian flamenco, in the life-time of jazz, has shown considerable powers of propagation within the Hispanic areas, though outside them it has had no popular influence. Latin-American music, on the other hand, has disputed Western popular music with jazz, its attack spearheaded by the tangos, rhumbas, and sambas, while it has, since the 1940s, actually encroached upon jazz itself with the fashion for mixed Cuban-jazz music. Caribbean music has made modest progress in America, Britain, Scandinavia, and West Africa, mainly through the miserable doggerel of the calypso, but perhaps (except for West Africa) only as a novelty. Flourishing traditions of light and popular music elsewhere have also imposed some limitations on jazz, though they have not prevented it establishing bridgeheads: the Italian *canzone*, the French *chanson* and accordion-type music, and various other older idioms have resisted it. Of course, except among particular age-groups or social groups, jazz, however diluted, has nowhere ever had a musical monopoly. Even in the U.S.A. other forms have maintained themselves, and everywhere such older kinds of dance as the waltz persist, though in a more modest position than before. Again, except in the most urbanized Anglo-Saxon areas, jazz has been far slower to penetrate the countryside than the town, the small town than the big city. But there can be no doubt that it is today a world idiom, not only in the hybrid form of jazz-tinged dance-music, but in a much more thoroughbred version. Nor that, but for political factors, it would be even more widespread.

How much of this is due to the prestige and propaganda of the U.S.A. and to the dominant position of the American entertainment industry is a matter for debate. Probably not very much, except perhaps for the original spread of hybrid jazz. The main international agency for the dissemination of the American way of life, Hollywood, has paid very

little attention to jazz, since this was and remains a minority taste in America. The American pop music industry has been much less capable of international penetration outside the Anglo-Saxon radius than jazz alone: until almost the present, Tin Pan Alley has not substantially disturbed the national pattern of the French, German, Italian, Spanish, etc., song-hits. In fact, jazz—especially authentic jazz in its various forms—has made its way under its own considerable power. Only when it had done so did the American Government recognize it as an agent of propaganda for the ‘American way of life’ in the Cold War, and use it to penetrate the East-West barrier, flooding the air with daily jazz broadcasts and sending prominent musicians abroad as ‘cultural ambassadors’. Since 1947 the expansion of jazz has therefore almost certainly owed something to official sponsorship. However, jazz had travelled a long way without it, and would undoubtedly have continued to do so in any country in which jazz records were freely available.

The most recent phase of the expansion of jazz is perhaps too early to assess: it is the entry of the almost undiluted rhythm and blues into pop music, as in the rock-and-roll or the British skiffle crazes. This is the product of the middle 1950s. In many ways it is probably the most formidable of the many advances jazz has so far made, for there can be no doubt that rhythm and blues have not only swamped ordinary pop music in America and Britain, at least in terms of the sales chart, but that their power to penetrate the juke-boxes of the world is far, far greater than that of any previous product of America’s Tin Pan Alley. It is an awe-inspiring experience to see substantially the same selection of shockers on the automatic gramophones of little Italian towns as in Manchester, and no doubt Wichita, and to reflect that complete freedom of cultural competition would almost certainly put them on those of Moscow and Shanghai. Perhaps this is because this latest fashion has reduced the music appeal to its simplest elements: a relentless, elementary beat, and a shouting voice. In America the phenomenon was a creation of the pop industry, analogous to the jazz injections of 1914–20 and 1935–40. In Britain, however, it had much more interesting origins, in a wholly spontaneous and uncommercial popular movement of amateur music-making with guitars and improvised rhythm instruments, with a repertoire of American folk-songs. These ‘skiffle groups’ which

flourished for a few months until killed by commercialization were the direct children of the New Orleans revival, and indeed originally consisted of singers and guitarists from revival bands who entertained the audience with blues and Leadbelly-type songs while the rest of the boys had a drink. The public for skiffle and rock-and-roll was wholly adolescent or sub-adolescent; indeed the habitual rock-and-roll fan, unless mentally rather retarded, tended to be between ten and fifteen years of age. Probably the universal appeal of the fashion was due to this infantilism. Though it had begun to recede slightly by 1960, the rhythm-and-blues element remained powerful in pop music addressed to juveniles, who had been discovered to constitute the major market for Tin Pan Alley in the prosperous fifties.

Notes

- [1.](#) W. C. Handy, *Father of the Blues* (London 1957), 64.
- [2.](#) Blesh and Janis, 190–1.
- [3.](#) Bertha Wood, Paul Leroy Howard (*Jazz Journal*, November 1957).
- [4.](#) Figures from Franklin Frazier, *The Negro in the United States* (revised edn New York 1957).
- [5.](#) Barry Ulanov, *Duke Ellington* (New York 1946), 279.
- [6.](#) Iain Lang, *Background to the Blues* (London n.d.), 13.
- [7.](#) The only general history of race records is S. B. Charters's *The Country Blues* (1960), but the specialist periodicals contain several learned explorations.
- [8.](#) S. Spaeth, *A History of Popular Music in America* (New York 1948), 369.
- [9.](#) Green and Laurie, 36, 39, Chapter 17.
- [10.](#) For different and unconvincing etymologies, see *Jazz, A Quarterly of American Music*, October 1958, and *Jazz Review*, March–August 1960.
- [11.](#) D. Boulton, *Jazz in Britain* (London 1958), 34–5.
- [12.](#) Handy, 63.
- [13.](#) Chilton in *Jazz Music* III, 6.
- [14.](#) Dates and titles from Spaeth.
- [15.](#) Quoted from Blesh, *Shining Trumpets* (New York 1946), 327–8. See also Neil Leonard Jr, *The Opposition to Jazz in the U.S. 1918–29* (*Jazz Monthly*, June, July 1958).
- [16.](#) Blesh, 329.
- [17.](#) Green and Laurie, 317; E. Borneman, *A Critic Looks at Jazz* (London, Jazz Music Books, 1946), 50–1, for details of the effect of the slump.
- [18.](#) Boulton, 59.
- [19.](#) *Melody Maker*, 1930, 155; 1935, 2 February; *Jazz Monthly*, March 1956, 30.
- [20.](#) Green and Laurie, 457.
- [21.](#) F. Ramsey Jr and C. E. Smith, *Jazzmen* (British edn, London 1957).
- [22.](#) E. Condon and R. Gehman, *Eddie Condon's Treasury of Jazz* (London 1957), 200.
- [23.](#) *Jazz* by E. F. Burian, the Czech *avant-gardist* theatrical producer (Prague 1928), is perhaps the first book on the subject by a Western leftist. The most important works issued by Marxists or

under left-wing auspices are S. Finkelstein, *Jazz, A People's Music* (New York 1948), and Iain Lang, *Background to the Blues*, both excellent; but a Marxist approach is widespread in Anglo-Saxon jazz criticism. Ernst Meyer, the Marxist musicologist, is one of the few writers in Eastern Europe to give jazz at least a qualified approval in the cold-war era in *Musik im Zeitgeschehen* (Berlin 1952); but he spent his emigration in England. However, the Soviet attitude since 1956 is no longer one of general hostility.

* Out of the seventy-six black musicians listed as 'giants of jazz' in Feather's *Encyclopedia* only three were born or raised in Chicago (one of them a performer on a minor instrument, the violin), as compared to nine in New York.

† Among musical sons of Louisville the best-known are J. Harrison (trombone), Al Casey (guitar), Lionel Hampton (rhythm)—who was, however, educated in Chicago—and Meade Lux Lewis (piano.)

‡ To mention only some born before 1914, when the Pittsburgh ghetto must have been very small—it is still not among the ten largest black communities—Earl Hines (piano), Mary Lou Williams (piano and arranger), Roy Eldridge (trumpet), Billy Eckstine (singer), Kenny Clark (drums). Younger Pittsburghians include Billy Strayhorn (arranger), Erroll Garner (piano), Ray Brown (bass).

§ The man chiefly responsible for this catalogue in the early stages was Clarence Williams (born 1893), a coloured composer, leader, and pianist, second only to W. C. Handy as a popularizer of jazz, who had been in music publishing since 1913.

¶ This contest is immortal because of the expert testimony of one Professor White, a blues writer called in by the court to explain what it was. 'Blues are blues', explained the professor. 'That's what blues are. See?'

|| See Chapter 10.

** Fascism in Germany and Italy, disputes between the British and American musicians' unions (1935–56), and the increasing cultural isolation of the U.S.S.R., where American jazz bands had toured in the 1920s, closed large areas of Europe to them. However, in Britain solo acts could still perform.

‡‡ Bing Crosby's brother Bob had launched a semi-commercial Dixieland band in 1937, and in 1939 an old Chicagoan, Muggsy Spanier, launched the short-lived and wholly enchanting career of his Ragtime band, while in New York an even more typical Chicagoan, Eddie Condon, made a hit with the old-fashioned unplanned jazz of his youth. But these were men from the old generations, not youngsters.